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Abstract

The following paper explores the rich history of German breweries in Texas, discussing their breakthrough innovations, origins, personal achievements, and lasting cultural impact which they have made on the state .

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German Breweries in Texas

Texas is home to one of the largest German populations in the United States of America, which is seen through the cultural footprint they have left on the Lone Star state. When mass German immigration started in 1842, they brought with them a love for beer and world-renowned brewing skills which have become a staple of Texas. Consequentially, every community containing a large number of these immigrants (with the exception of El Paso and Nacogdoches) established a brewery. The greatest concentration of Germans settled in an area deemed the "German belt," which lies smack dab in the middle of Austin, Houston, and San Antonio; even continuing up into the Hill Country. This belt of exceptional German influence also, un-coincidentally, is home to "95% of the breweries that ever existed in Texas."

As German immigrants first arrived, the breweries they established in their settlements resembled very little of the large-scale national brewers which supply a vast majority of Americans in modern times. They were considerably smaller, taking the form of home breweries, and did not produce near enough beer to sell to an entire community, much less the entire state of Texas. Therefore, home-brewers did not turn the required profit to make a living, resulting in a majority working in other professions. This fact is reflected by the numbers of the 1850 census, as only 19 brewers and distillers were recorded, and none if you were to look at the manufacturing schedule. For them, it was simply a way to have available beer and feel at least slightly at home in the entirely different area of the world they were settling down in.

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As more and more Germans continued flooding into Texas throughout the 1840s and 1850s, their small home breweries began to transform. Larger commercial breweries sprung up, which possessed the ability to supply beer to a greater region of people than ever before possible. This explains the 1860 census numbers, which saw a significant decrease (down to 11) in the amount of brewers and distillers in the state, as less breweries became capable of supplying more people. William Menger's Western Brewery, which opened its doors in 1855 in San Antonio, is considered the first of this breed of breweries. It boasted the title of largest brewery in Texas at the time it was shutdown in 1878, and also functioned as a hotel. Working in the hospitality business on the side was not uncommon in this era, as other prominent brewers such as Thomas Ingenhuitt (Comfort) and Charles Nimitz (Fredericksburg) also ran hotels similar to Menger.

Heinrich Kreische's Kreische Brewery in La Grange opened up in the year 1872, and is considered the second commercial brewery in Texas. By 1879, due to the technological ingenuity displayed by Kreische, the establishment found itself in the position of third largest brewery in the Lone Star state. This was made possible with Menger's observation of a ravine of spring water which ran beneath the hill that his brewery was perched on. Realizing this, he created a nine-step system which used gravity to assist in the production process, and allowed for a method to more efficiently brew quality beer. A combination of technological innovations and Kreische's sudden death in 1882 led the brewery to shut its' doors for good in 1884. Despite the efficiency

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of the operation he left behind, “Kreische’s Bluff Beer” was unable to compete with the new age of breweries to come.

Technological innovations evolved the brewing industry exponentially as the 20th century approached, giving companies the means to further reach new markets of customers not available in the past. From this mechanized, large-scale breweries arose which not only sold their beer on the local level, but across the entire state (and in certain cases other states as well). Through pasteurization, brewers were able to both improve the taste of their product and make it safer for their customers to consume. The process uses heat to stunt the growth of yeast within beer that has already gone through packaging, multiplying the shelf life of it of the product. With pasteurization, the beer was able to cope with much longer periods of transport and, as a result, maintain a higher quality when it reached far-away destinations. Apart from the pasteurization process, the invention of commercial refrigeration further added to the longevity of beer being transported. Along with this, it also enabled Germans to sell their superior-tasting lager beer all year long, instead of only certain seasons. Although the latter innovations played a role, the construction of a vast railway system reaching nearly every corner of Texas was the most vital of all these breakthroughs. Additionally, its’ creation put a massive dent in the time required for the shipment of beer from brewers to their customer base. When combined with pasteurization techniques and commercial refrigeration, railroads were the final piece of the puzzle which enabled Texan brewers to reach a market outside of solely their own state.

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Lone Star Brewery, founded in San Antonio in 1884 by Adolphus Busch alongside a group of local businessmen, is the first example of a mechanized, large-scale regional breweries to pop up in Texas. Lone Star sold beer in Texas, Mexico, and even California; revolutionizing breweries throughout the state with its' size and production capabilities. Not long after, fellow San Antonio juggernaut Pearl Brewery (originally San Antonio Brewing Association) burst onto the scene as the only other large regional brewer of the 1880s. By 1890, Lone Star and Pearl breweries were established as the twin pillars of beer production in the state, putting a majority of smaller breweries out of commission (besides a few with extremely loyal customers) due to their widespread customer bases. Founded by Otto Koehler in 1886, he ran and operated Pearl Brewery until the time of his death in 1914. In the wake of this tragedy Koehler's wife, Emma, took over, eventually leading the business to become the largest brewery in Texas by the year 1916.

Prohibition in the United States began on January 16, 1919 and outlawed the production, importation, transportation, or sale of alcohol under any circumstances. This era of alcoholic abstinence hit the Lone Star state hard, forcing 13 commercial breweries around the state to cease distribution of beer. For the time being, brewers shuffled into various other occupations in an attempt to continue making a living. Most "switched to nonalcoholic beverages such as sodas or 'near beers,'" but there were still others which looked to branch out from the drink industry. For example, Pearl Brewery tried their hand in multiple fields, selling ice cream while also running a sign company

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out of their plant. Kosmos Spoetzl, owner of Spoetzl Brewery and creator of still exceedingly popular Shiner beer, found himself selling ice in order to get by.

Following Prohibition, the number of local and regional breweries fell victim to a rapid decline. Almost every small-scale brewery was eradicated permanently, leaving only a few of the major commercial plants as the lone survivors. Even some of the largest regional breweries themselves did not reopen after the law was repealed, expressing the impact the 13 year drought had on even the biggest producers across the state. Most notable of the group which closed was Koehler's Lone Star Brewery, which up until the point of Prohibition had maintained a status as one of Texas' top beer suppliers. In the post-Prohibition era, an influx of national chains filed into Texas such as Anheuser-Busch and Miller. This led to a further drop in local and regional Texas breweries, as even the largest regional brewers found it difficult to compete with the manufacturing capabilities of national corporations.

While not as abundant as they once were, the breweries established by German immigrants to Texas, along with their enthusiasm for beer, have made an undeniable impact on the state. Remnants of their imprint can be seen to this day, whether it be less obvious (such as the new brewers adopting Koehler's Lone Star name) or through clear examples like Shiner beer (which is still widely popular), Pearl Brewery (oldest active brewery in Texas), and Kreische's landmark brewery on Monument Hill. Although prohibition coupled with technological innovations has allowed national chains to strike out the diversity of local and regional German breweries, there are still some which exist and thrive to this day.

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